

spring. Mulching around the plants during summer will also encourage steady growth.

Cauliflowers will need protection from discoloration by the sun, which can turn their curds yellow. To prevent this, use the leaves to form a shield over the curd (see tip box, right). This method can also be used to provide protection from the cold in winter. Firm the soil around the plants to give them extra support and protection in frosty and windy weather.

## HARVESTING AND STORING

Harvest cauliflowers when the curds are firm—if left in the ground, the flower buds will open and the cauliflower will deteriorate. If you are not harvesting for immediate use, cut the heads from the roots, leaving some of the outer leaves on the curd. This will help to protect it from damage and keep it humid. Store summer cauliflowers by hanging them in a cool, dark place, and spray them with water occasionally. They will last for up to three weeks. Fall and winter cauliflowers store for longer.

Miniature cauliflowers don't keep, so should be harvested and eaten as soon as possible.

## TIP BLANCHING

Tying the cauliflowers' leaves so that they cover the curds forming a "shield" is usually done in summer as it prevents the sun from reaching the curds and turning them yellow. However, it will also help to protect cauliflowers from frost in winter, since the leaves act as a layer of effective insulation.

Once plants are large enough, simply wrap the leaves inward, making sure to cover the curd completely, and fix in place with garden string or soft twine. Ensure that plants are dry or you may encourage the cauliflower to rot. Some varieties are self-blanching, and their inner leaves will naturally fold inward. They may still benefit from protection in winter.



**Ensure that no light can reach the cauliflower curds, since this would cause them to discolor. Keep the string in place until you are ready to harvest.**